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Immigration Cheat Sheets

Supporting Migrants To Make Informed Decisions When Accessing Education Abroad

Overview

Our project, in brief.

Our UNSDG

10.7 Facilitate orderly, safe, regular and responsible migration and mobility of people, including through the implementation of planned and well-managed migration policies.

Our UNSDG aims to reduce inequalities through global migration, aiming to bring safety, mobility, education, and prosperity to people and their communities.

Our Mission Statement

Addressing Barriers to Informed Decision Making When Accessing Education Abroad

01

Our Process

Over thirteen weeks, we worked face-to-face with international students via semi-structured interviews to learn about their experiences when accessing education abroad.

02

Our Findings

We found users suffered from isolation and decision paralysis, struggling to make informed decisions about immigration due to fragmented information and unreliable sources.

03

Our Response

In response, we created a knowledge platform that supports the exploration, planning and comparison of different countries, universities, and local areas. Aiming to support students in their journeys through unified, well-structured and accessible information directly sourced from our user engagement.

Interview Results

What we heard from users.

Key Barriers

- Lack of Local Context
- Difficulty Making Comparisons
- Lack of Community
- Decision Paralysis
- Lack of Confidence in Sources

+

Key Motivations

- Economic mobility
- Access to freedom of movement
- Access to better quality education
- Access to Technology Sector

Requirements

What our users needed.

Mind Mapping

Survey

Semi-Structured Interviews

Functional

1. Make Comparisons
2. Make Plans
3. Single Source of Information
4. Connect with Peers

+

Data

1. Local Information
2. Economic Data
3. University Reputation
4. Weather

+

Social

1. Authentic Connection
2. Collaboration
3. Community Building
4. Trustworthy Sources

+

Environmental

1. Offline Functionality
2. Cross-platform Access
3. Affordable Price Point

LoFi Prototyping

How we responded to our requirements.

Ideation

Based on our requirements, we developed a wide range of concepts spanning data platforms, collaboration hubs, planning apps, and comparison interfaces. Selecting Immigration Cheat Sheets and Global Study Hub for Lo-Fi prototyping.

Illustrator + Figma

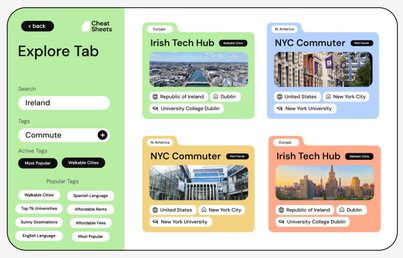
Mind Mapping

Immigration Cheat Sheets

ICS is a platform that cuts through the noise and supports informed planning, comparisons and decision making for student migrants.

Requirements

- Comparisons
- Decision Making
- Planning
- Useful Data



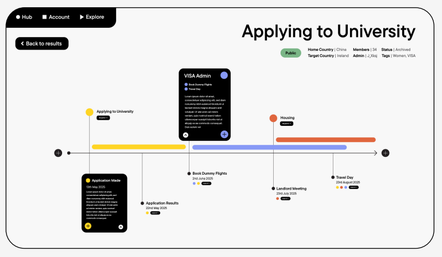
+

Global Study Hub

GSH is a platform that brings student migrants together to plan their immigration journey and build communities, all centred around a timeline motif.

Requirements

- Planning
- Community
- Collaboration
- Administration



HiFi Prototyping

Moving from idea to implementation.

Illustrator + PPT

SWOT Analysis

Selecting our Idea

ICS was chosen because of its simplicity, accessibility, and direct link to user insights. The interface successfully aids decision-making and comparison-making by putting actionable data in the hands of users.

Design

ICS uses a colourful 'folder' motif based on simple, accessible information presentation. Users navigate the three pathways using a central hub, allowing them to create, compare, explore, or get personalised recommendations.

Evaluation

Critical Engagement with our idea and output.

SUS + Nielson's Heuristics + User Interview

Strengths

Users liked the **simple, colourful design** and felt empowered to make informed decisions. The interface onboards users with a helpful introduction, using **intuitive progress** markers on the quiz page, and a helpful preview to prevent errors. The explore page caters for casual users and detailed planners with quick links and **advanced search** options. **Navigation** is aided with a central hub and helpful colour coding for each pathway.

Weaknesses

Elements of the quiz **lack clarity**, and navigation isn't always intuitive. The **brevity** of the cheat sheets are a double-edged sword, sometimes creating more questions than answers. The **lack of social features** and in-depth planning pushes users off the platform, limiting its utility.

Appendix A: Interview Guide

I. Time Guide

Introduction - 5 mins
Local Media and Culture- 10 mins
Preparing for Life in a New Country - 10 mins
Cost of Living- 10 mins
Conclusion - 5 mins

II. Introduction

1. **Introduce yourself**
    - Thank them for joining
    - Talk about who we are as a team

2. **A brief outline of the structure:**
    - Politics (10 mins)
    - Culture (10 mins)
    - Housing (10 mins)

3. **Explain our Mission Statement:**
    - Breaking down barriers to accessing education abroad
    - Our goal is to find out some of the barriers that you experienced

4. **Ethics Statement:**
    - We want you to feel comfortable at all times
    - You are welcome to refuse any of the questions
    - Please let us know if you want to end the interview at any point

5. **Privacy Statement:**
    - This interview will be audio recorded
    - We will store the audio recording for 24 hours for transcription purposes

- After 24 hours, the audio will be deleted
- Your transcript will be 100% anonymous
- At the end of the project, we will delete your anonymous transcript

III. Local Media and Culture

1. **How did you decide where to study abroad?**

   Optional Prompts:

   - Did you consider other places - if so, why?
   - What tools did you use? E.g online research/agency
   - What sort of info were you looking for?
   - Ask for more examples.

2. **Did you know much about Irish culture/politics before moving here?**

   Optional Prompts:

   - What was your understanding?
   - What were your sources?
   - Was there anything unexpected about Ireland's Politics
   - Ask for more examples.

3. **Did you search for any local media before moving? (E.g. News, TV)**

   Optional Prompts:

   - If not, why?
   - If so, how?
   - Would local media have influenced your decisions?
   - Ask for more examples.

4. **What were the most frustrating or time-consuming parts of this process?**

IV. Preparing for Life in a New Country

1. **What surprised you about Irish Culture? Can you give a recent example?**

   Optional Prompts:

   - Cost of Living, Regional differences (eg, north vs south), Safety, Friendliness, Transport.
   - What are the **differences or similarities**
   - Ask for more examples.

2. **What were your sources of information about Irish culture?**

   Optional Prompts:

   - Film, TV, Social Media, Online Search, Stereotypes
   - Ask for more examples.

3. **Were you worried about adjusting to life in Ireland?**

   Optional Prompts:

   - If so, why?
   - What would have helped?
   - What weren't you aware of?
   - Ask for more examples.

4. **Is there anything you wished you'd known first before coming here?**

   Optional Prompts:

   - Work Culture, Language, Food, Rudeness vs Politeness
   - Ask for more examples.

   -

5. **What was the most frustrating or time-consuming part of researching Irish Culture?**

V. Cost of Living

1. **Were you concerned about the cost of living in Ireland?**

Optional Prompts:

- What were your sources of info?
- Did you find it difficult to know where to start?
- Ask for more examples.

2. **Did you compare Ireland with other countries?**

Optional Prompts:

- Did that influence your decision to move?
- Ask for more examples.

3. **Were you aware of the housing market in Ireland?**

Optional Prompts:

- If so, how did you find out?
- If not, would it have influenced your decision?
- Ask for more examples.

4. **Did you struggle to find local renting platforms?**

Optional Prompts:

- What were your methods?
- What info was missing?
- Ask for more examples.

5. **What were the most frustrating or time-consuming parts of this process?**

Closing Question:

If you could write a list of all the things you wish you'd known about Ireland before coming here, what would it say?

Appendix B: Communication Materials

Appendix B1: Participant Recruitment Email (Interview Invitation)

Hey!

My name is Apollo Musibi, and I am an M.Sc. Information Systems student at UCD. On behalf of my amazing groupmates: **Ssu-Han**, **Yatharth**, **Patrick** and **Meiyu**, I would like to thank you for agreeing to be part of our research for our project. We really appreciate your time!

To get a better idea of what we are doing and the goal of this project, please take a moment to read the **Project Info and Consent Form document** attached below.

Privacy and Consent
We take keeping your personal information and data safe very seriously. We will strictly follow all data privacy and protection regulations in accordance with the provisions of the Data Protection Act (2018) and the General Data Protection Regulation (2016).

Because of this, you will need to read and sign the attached consent form before we can start this exercise. This form formalizes our agreement and outlines how your data will be used.

Scheduling our Meeting
Once you have signed the consent form, please use this link to let us know your preferred meeting time and date. We will set up the meeting based on the times and dates you provide, so please make sure you choose a time that works best for you.

If you have any questions or need more information, just reply to this email and we'll get back to you quickly. Thank you again for being willing to help us!

Warm regards,
User-Centered Design (UXD) Master's Student

Appendix B2: Questionnaire Follow-up Email

Hey!

Thank you again for participating in the interviews - we really appreciate your input!

To wrap up your participation in this project, we just have one quick final step: please take a moment to fill in this short form [Link to Form] with the requested details.

Please know that your privacy is still our top priority. The information you provide here is **completely anonymous**, and we will continue to strictly follow all **GDPR** policies to keep your data safe.

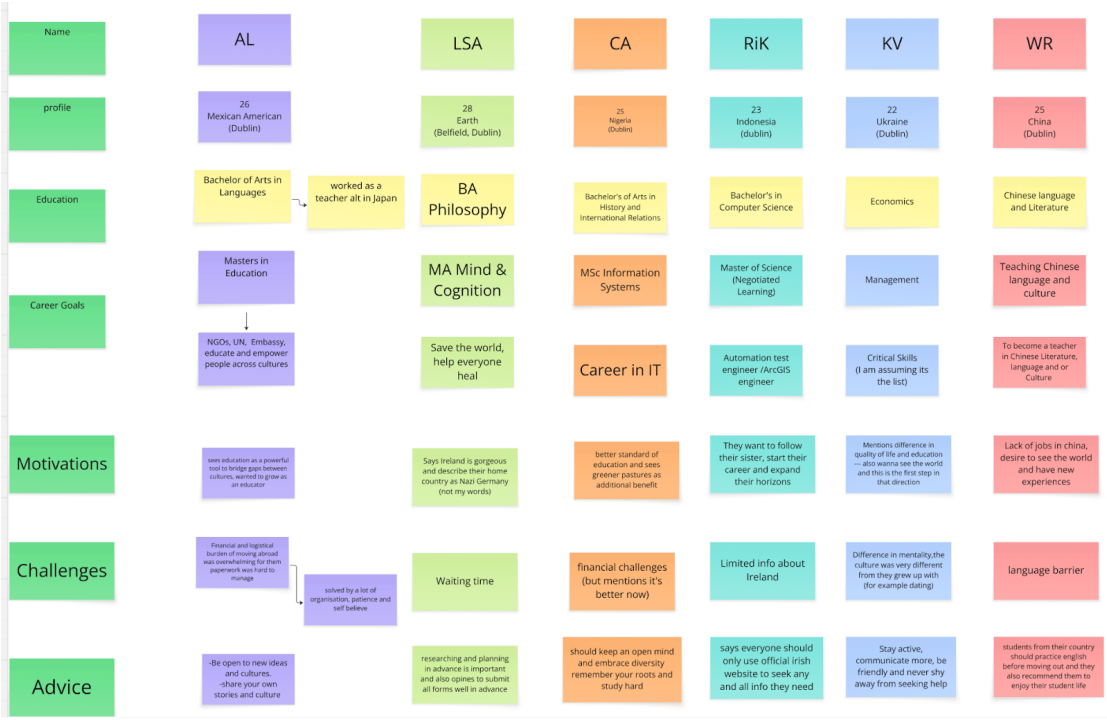
Warm regards,
User-Centered Design (UXD) Master's Student

Appendix C: Questionnaire & Answers

Appendix C1: Questionnaire Form

1. Name:
2. Age:
3. Nationality:
4. Current location (county/city):
5. Educational Background (Field of study prior to pursuing education abroad)
6. Current Programme/Field of Study:
7. Career Goals
8. Student Narratives and Insights
9. What motivated you to pursue education abroad?
10. What were the biggest challenges you faced when applying for or starting your studies abroad?
11. What advice would you give to a new student coming from your home country?

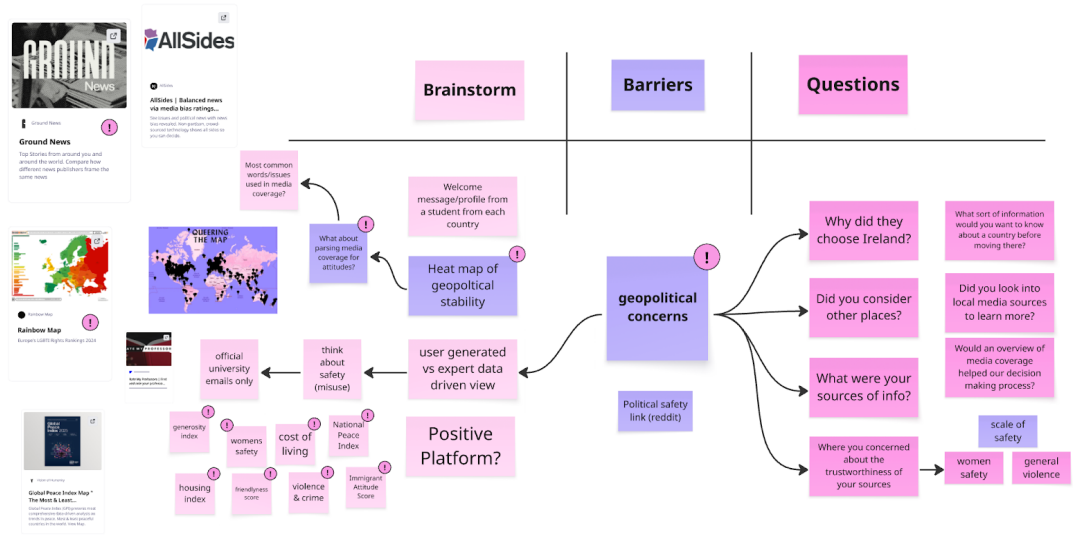
Appendix C2: Questionnaire Responses



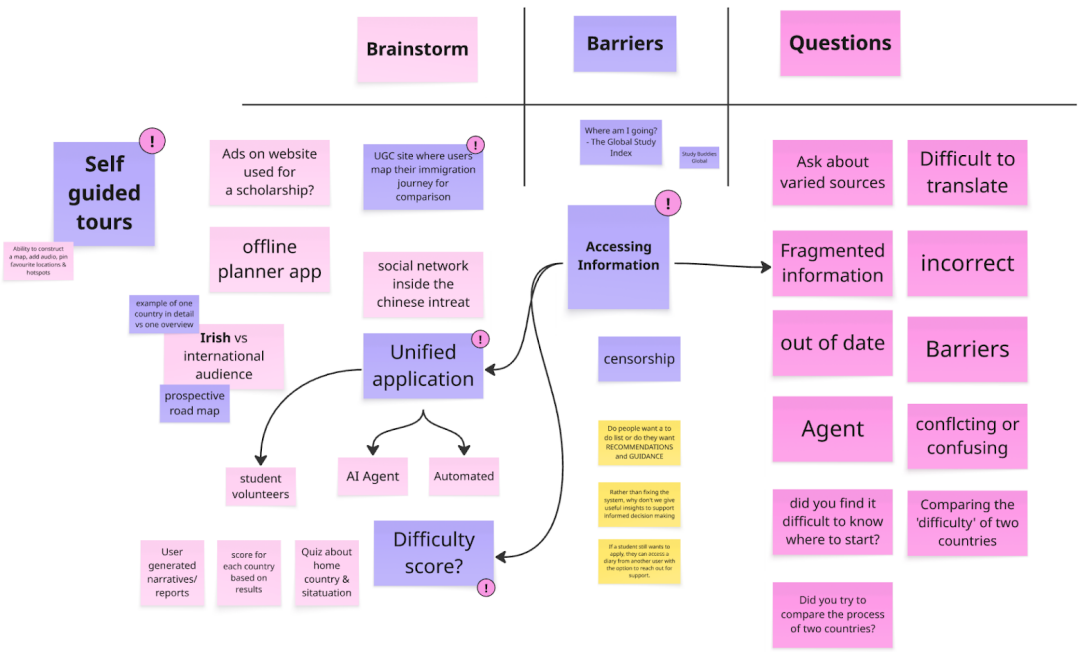
Appendix D: Brainstorming

This appendix contains all brainstorming sheets, sticky-note maps, rough schematics, and early system ideation created.

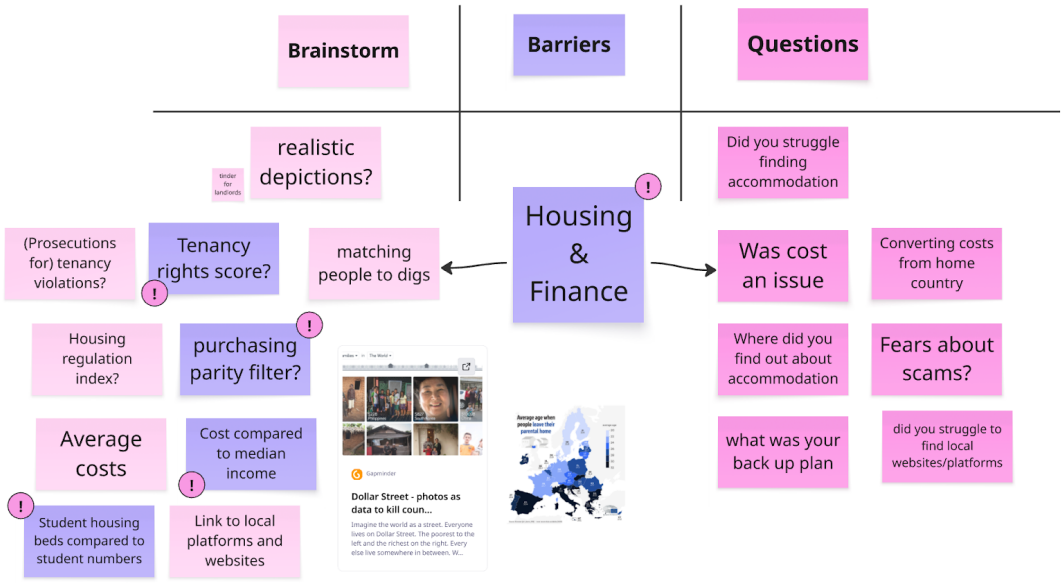
D1 Brainstorm Map: Geopolitical Concerns



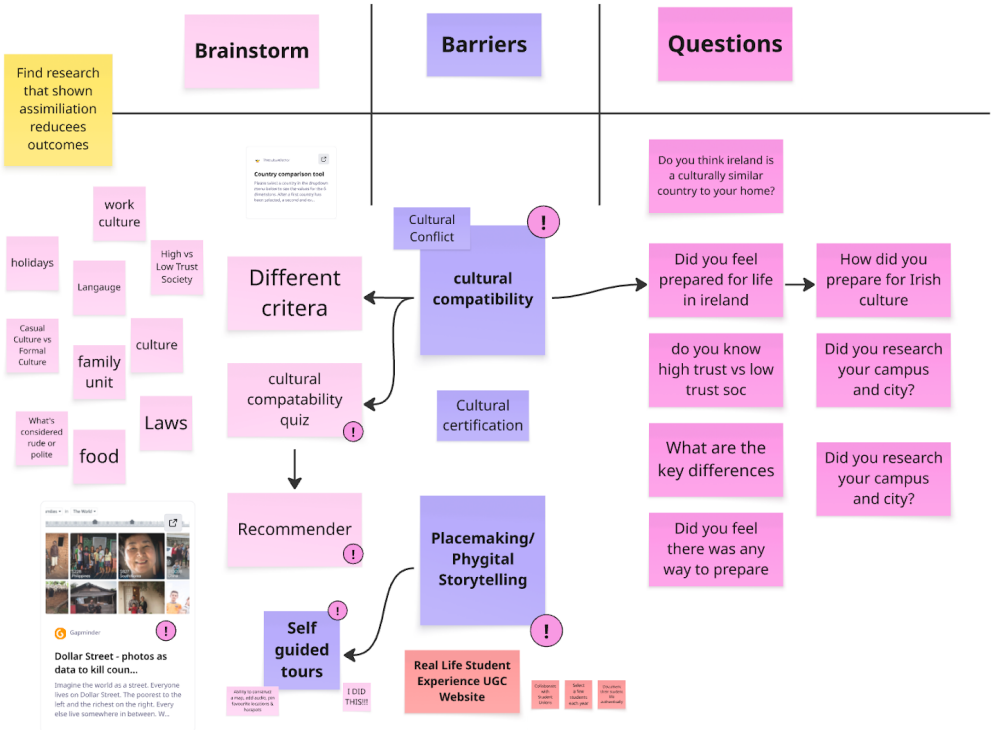
D2 Brainstorm Map: Accessing Information



D3 Brainstorm Map: Housing & Finance

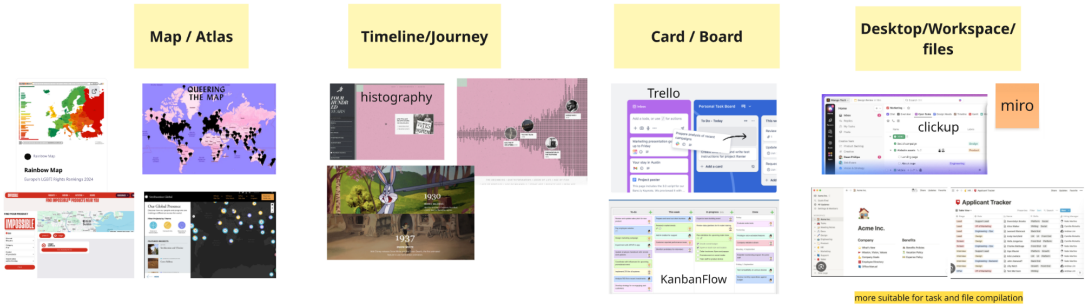


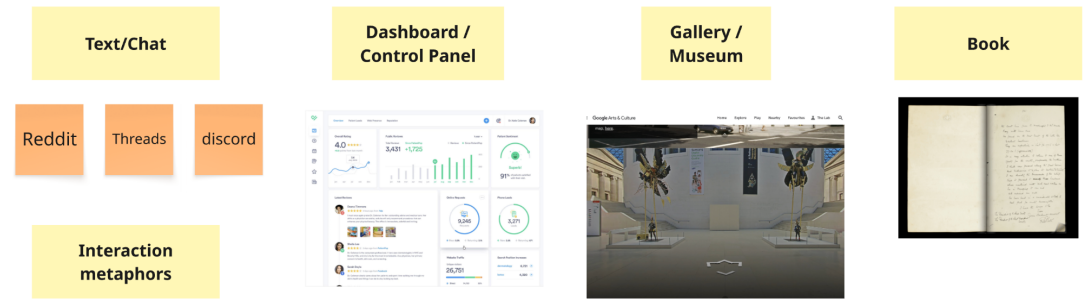
D4 Brainstorm Map: Cultural Compatibility



Appendix E: Interaction Metaphors

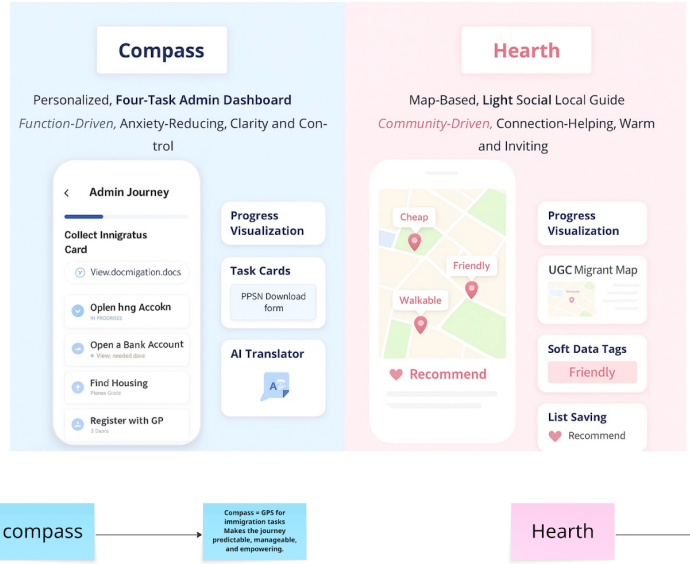
This section includes interaction metaphor inspirations gathered during early UX ideation (e.p, Map, Timeline, Dashboard, Board, Chat, Book).





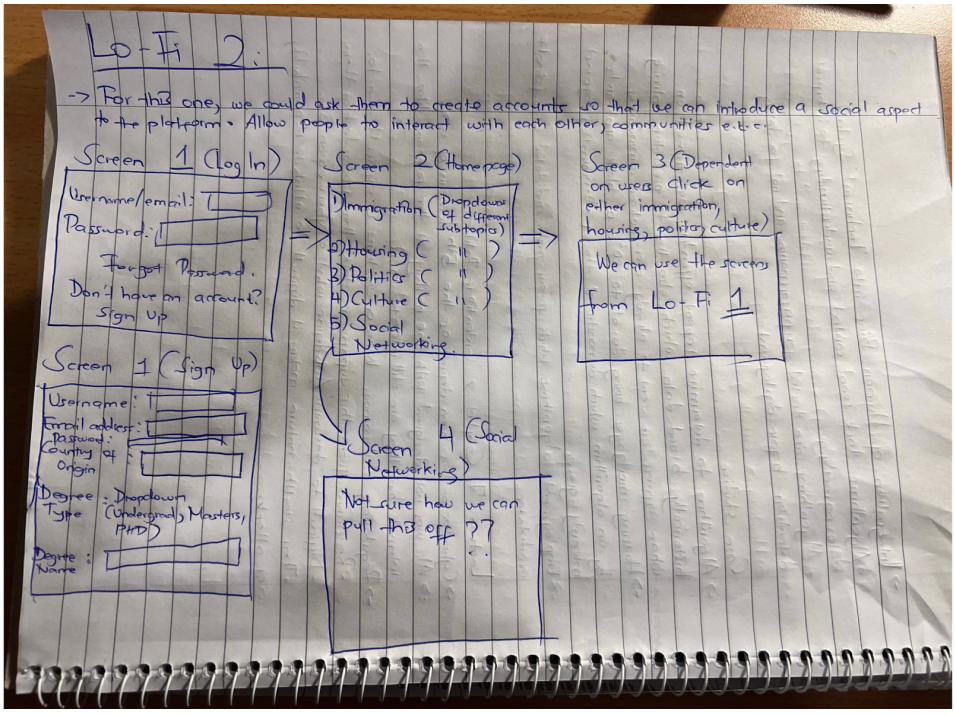
Appendix F: Concept Sketches and Structure Exploration

F1 Compass & Hearth Concept Drafts

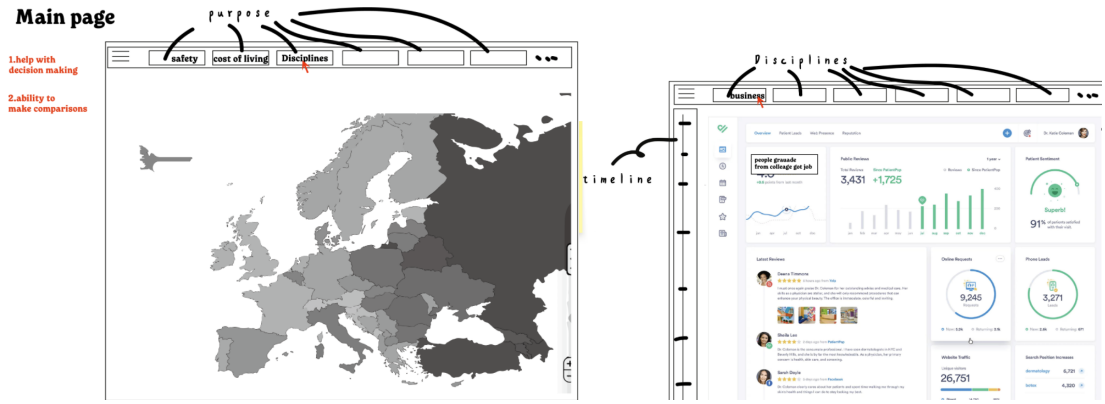


F2 Migrant Storytelling Interaction & Positivity Platform

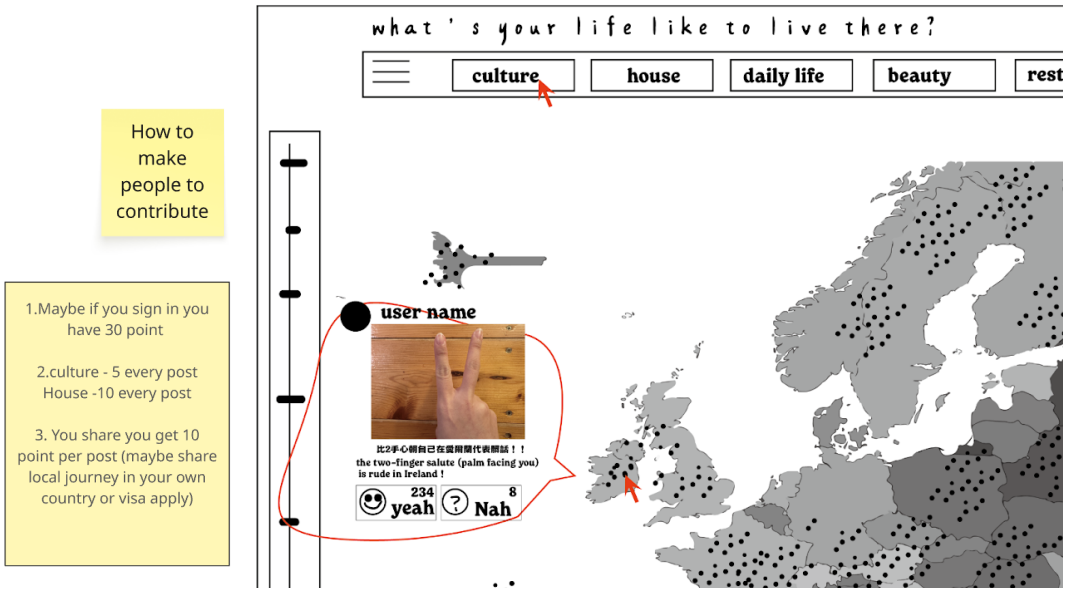
F2.1 Prototype Sketch – Interactive Migrant Story Map (Version 1)



F2.2 Prototype Sketch – Interactive Migrant Story Map (Version 2)

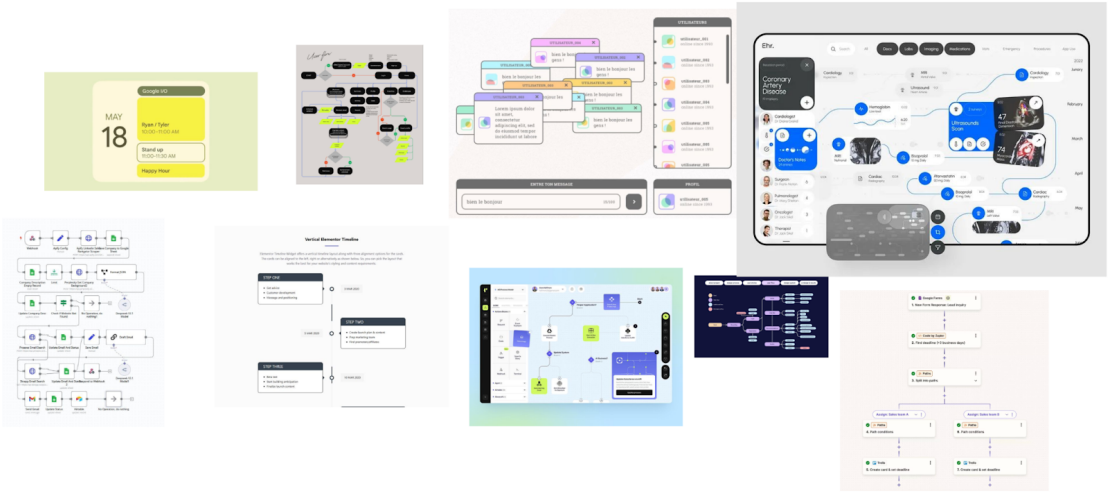


F2.3 Prototype Sketch: Timeline Story Browsing & Positivity Platform

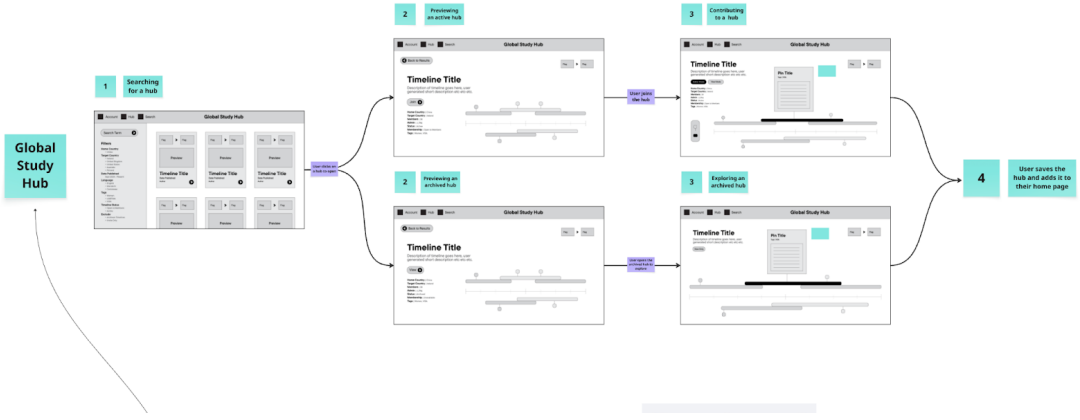


F3 Global Study Hub (GSH)

F3.1 Global Study Hub (GSH) Line flow Inspiration Images

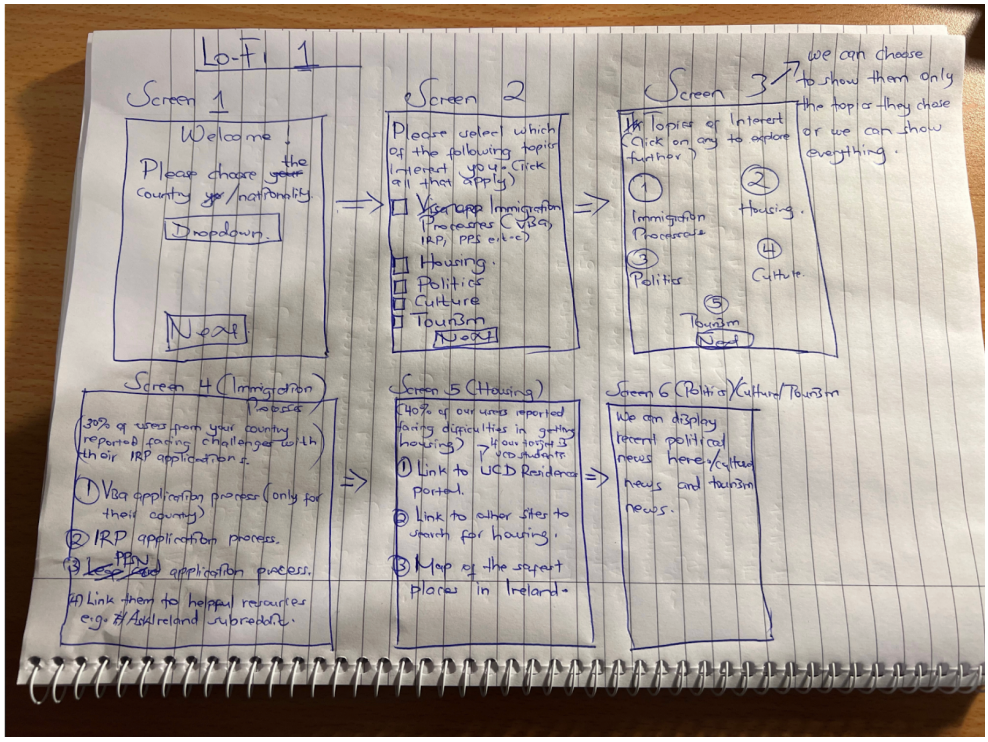


F3.2 Global Study Hub (GSH) Rough Sketch



F4 Immigration Cheat Sheet (ICS)

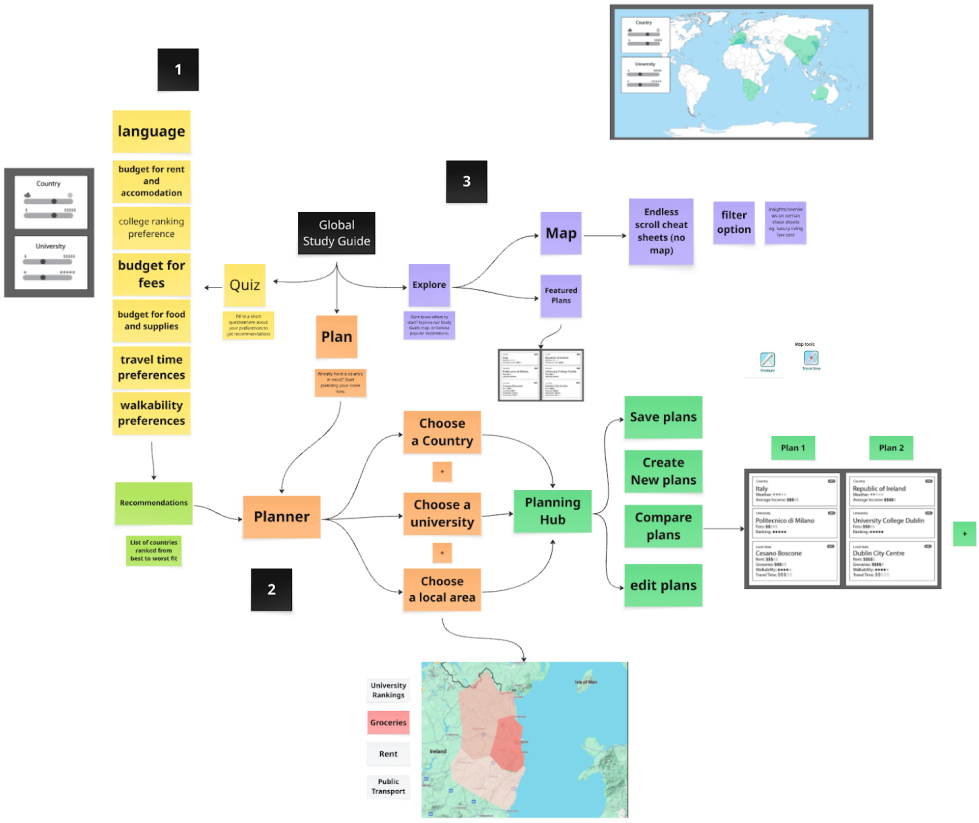
F4.1 Immigration Cheat Sheet (ICS) Rough + Student Housing Rights



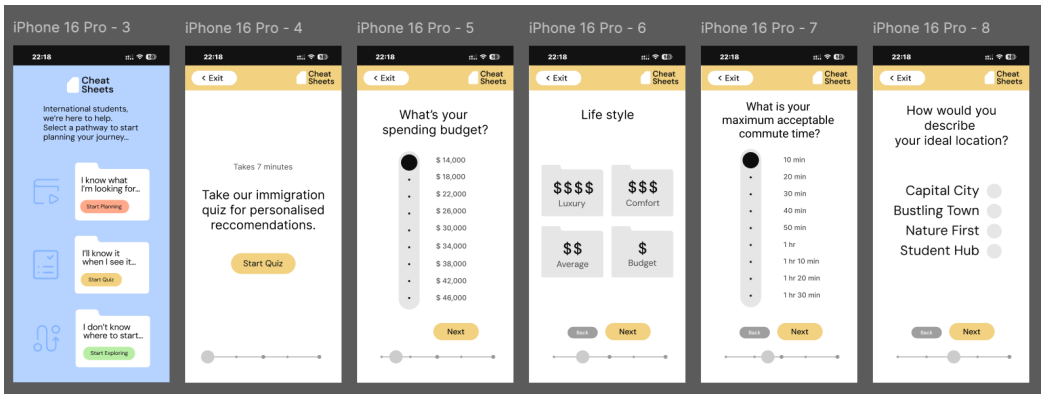
F4.2 Immigration Cheat Sheet (ICS) Visual References

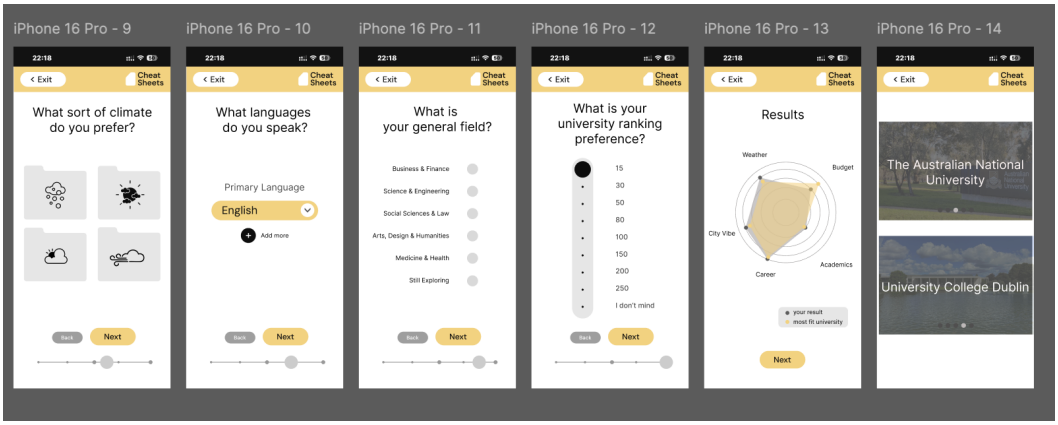


F4.3 Immigration Cheat Sheet (ICS) Rough Structure



F4.4 Immigration Cheat Sheet (ICS) Hi-Fi Prototype V1





Appendix G: Heuristic Evaluation

Heuristic Evaluation of the Immigration Cheat Sheets Prototype:

This section will cover the evaluation of our hi-fi prototype - Immigration Cheat Sheets. According to Erin (2025), conducting usability evaluations on high-fidelity prototypes leads to measurable improvements in usability metrics such as task success rates, efficiency, and user satisfaction. For the purposes of this evaluation, we will be using Nielsen's Usability Heuristics as our framework.

These heuristics are:

1. Visibility of system status.
2. Match between the system and the real world.
3. User control and freedom.
4. Consistency and standards.
5. Error prevention.
6. Recognition rather than recall.
7. Flexibility and efficiency of use.
8. Aesthetic and minimalist design.
9. Recognise, diagnose and recover from errors.
10. Help and documentation.

Table G.1: Heuristic Evaluation Detailed Findings

Section of Prototype	Heuristic Violated	Description of Violation	Severity Rating (0-4)	Suggested Improvements	Improvements Implemented in the Final Version
Cheat Sheets Hub	Help and document ation	In our first prototype, the user was not clearly directed on what action to take. The only sort of guidance which was visible was, "Let's start with"	1	We already have a description section for each action but maybe we can add a little description for the landing page itself.	Each module, i.e. Create, Quiz and Explore, now has relevant descriptions which explain what they are about, and we have improved the user interface by adding icons for each of them.

Quiz Page	Help and documentation	In our first prototype, we did not provide enough information about the quiz and the description was vague and had a grammatical error.	2	We could add a little more description about the quiz itself and maybe prepare the users for the questions ahead.	We have added additional information on the quiz such as how long it will take, the purpose for the quiz, a progress bar at the bottom to show the user where they are on the quiz journey and a "Start Quiz" button.
Quiz Page (Lifestyle Goals Question)	User control and freedom	There was no navigation option to go back to the previous screen.	2	We should add proper navigation buttons.	We have added the necessary navigation buttons to the interface.
Quiz Page (Budget Question)	User control and freedom	The user might not have fit the cost of living standards which we had provided and we did not give them an option to select if they did not know what their budget was.	2	We could add an option for the user to select an option outside the range we have provided.	We have added an "I don't know" option for users who do not have a budget in mind.

Quiz Page (Commute Time Question)	User control and freedom	The user might not have fit the commute time options which we had provided..	2	We should provide users with more flexibility in the options.	We have increased the range of commute time and provided two additional options to our users i.e. if they want to live on campus or if they don't have an answer to the question.
Quiz Page (General Field of Study)	Error prevention	In the general field of study options provided, we did not take into account the possibility of a user's degree of choice overlapping between different categories. This might have led to the user getting confused about what option to pick.	2	We could let the users select multiple fields in case they have overlapping fields of study or interdisciplinary backgrounds.	We have added an option for our users to select multiple fields of study.

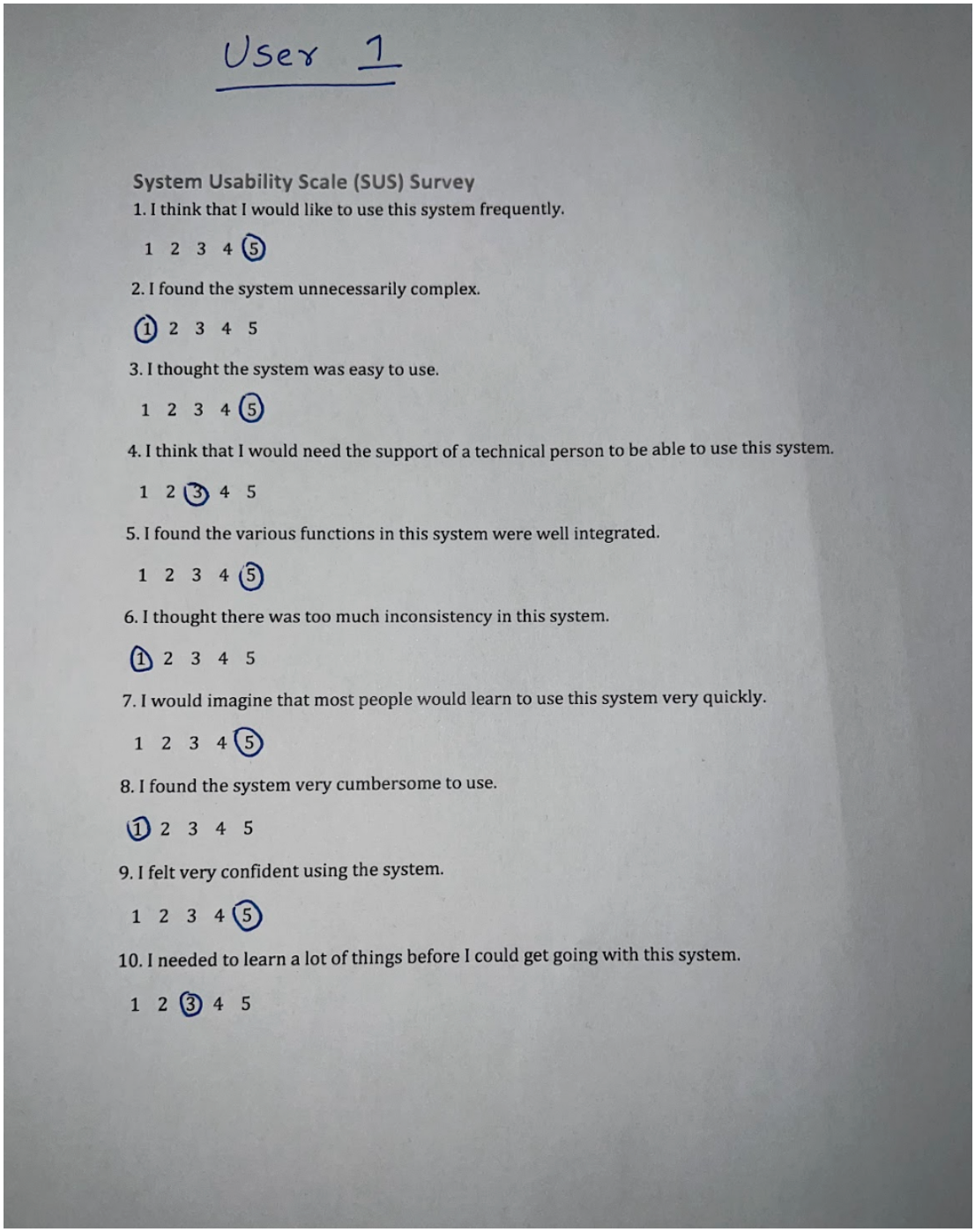
Quiz Page (My Results)	Error prevention	On this page we had options to go back or to get results. We did not display the summary of their answers.	3	Our users should have the option to review their previous answers in case they want to make any changes or to just verify that all their answers were correct.	We have now added the summary of all answers selected by our users so that they can verify them before proceeding.
Quiz Page (My Results)	Help and documentation	The university recommendations were not detailed enough.	4	We should provide our users with more information about their results.	We have added an option to expand on the recommendations provided and now our users get to see more information about the results they are being shown.
Create Page (Create New Sheet)	Help and documentation	The location section of the prototype was a graphical way for users to input their desired location but it did not have adequate information to help the user perform the action.	4	We should change this section and make it more user friendly.	We have revamped the section and removed the graphical mode of input and replaced it with a manual way for our users to input their desired location.

Create Page (Create New Sheet)	User control and freedom	In this section, the user did not have an option to name their new cheat sheet.	3	We should allow our users to name their sheets.	We have added the functionality of naming new sheets.
My Sheets Page	User control and freedom	There was no navigation option for the user to go to the previous page or go to the homepage.	4	We should provide navigation buttons to our users so that they can perform the necessary actions.	We have added navigation buttons to go to the previous page and to the home page.
Explore Section	Help and Documentation/User control and freedom	There was no information about how our users should interact with the interface. There were no navigation buttons in the entire section.	4	We should rework the entire explore section to accommodate for all the problems we found in our analysis.	We have completely revamped this section and added information about what the section entails and how the users should interact with it. In addition to the rectifications made in this section, we have also added a search functionality which allows our users to filter out results based on their preferences.

Appendix H: SUS Report Results

This appendix contains the raw System Usability Scale (SUS) response from the participant.

The following image shows the raw SUS survey response from **User 1**.



User 1

System Usability Scale (SUS) Survey

1. I think that I would like to use this system frequently.

1 2 3 4 (5)

2. I found the system unnecessarily complex.

(1) 2 3 4 5

3. I thought the system was easy to use.

1 2 3 4 (5)

4. I think that I would need the support of a technical person to be able to use this system.

1 2 (3) 4 5

5. I found the various functions in this system were well integrated.

1 2 3 4 (5)

6. I thought there was too much inconsistency in this system.

(1) 2 3 4 5

7. I would imagine that most people would learn to use this system very quickly.

1 2 3 4 (5)

8. I found the system very cumbersome to use.

(1) 2 3 4 5

9. I felt very confident using the system.

1 2 3 4 (5)

10. I needed to learn a lot of things before I could get going with this system.

1 2 (3) 4 5